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Searchers scour Crowders Mountain for hawk that flew coop

By Scot Hull
Star Staff Writer

KINGS MOUNTAIN — Bunky the red-tailed hawk is missing and his handlers are worried he may die if he's not found in the next 10 to 12 days.

The 12-year-old Western Morph red-tailed bird flew off Crowders Mountain Tuesday afternoon during the filming of a Duke Power environmental commercial.

Carolina Raptor Center, just west of Charlotte, is Bunky's home.

Pat Marcum, executive director of the center, said falconer Bob Pendergrass and Bunky were on top of Crowders Mountain

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Carolina Raptor Center

for the commercial when Bunky flew the coop.

"Bunky got out of the falconer's hands and got caught in the updraft," she said. "He disappeared over the side and hasn't been found."

Pendergrass, an expert falconer, borrowed Bunky from the Raptor Center.

"He's probably one of the finest falconers in the business," Mrs. Marcum said.

The transmitter Bunky usually wears wasn't around his neck, she added.

"This is the first time something like this has happened," she said. "There's no telling where that bird is."

Mrs. Marcum said Bunky is a special bird and is in captivity because he can't take care of himself.

"He can fly but he won't hunt," she said.

"When he was a baby, someone tried to make a pet out of him. Now, he sees humans as his species and depends on them for food."

It's a real problem, she said, because Bunky may approach a human who may misunderstand the bird's intentions.

"They may think he wants to attack them, but he's just looking for food," she said.

Bunky has been with the Raptor Center for seven years and is one of 63 birds the center uses in its educational program.

"He's a great bird, and so gentle," Mrs. Marcum said. "But there's always a risk

when we do something like this."

The bird is 15 inches tall with a bright red tail. His wing span is approximately four feet.

"He's an extremely beautiful bird," Mrs. Marcum said. "He is not a dangerous bird." It is against the law to hold raptors without proper permits, Mrs. Marcum said.

Anyone with information about Bunky may call the Raptor Center at 875-6521, 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. weekdays; 872-4348 or 279-6828 after 5 p.m.

"We are all really concerned," Mrs. Marcum said. "If you see him, please call us. We want him back."